resources. Despite the promises of the Obama-era pivot and a number of achievements, world opinion believed America was in retreat from Asia while China was ascendant.[35] Obama's rebalance was increasingly seen as mainly rhetoric, while Beijing was not deterred from militarizing the South China Sea, threatening Taiwan, or continuing its military buildup. Not only did Washington seem outmaneuvered in the South China Sea, but China's new economic initiatives seemed to promise more opportunity than the TPP, especially given US domestic opposition to the pact from both Democrats and Republicans. And while American policy makers would repeatedly argue that the United States was more engaged in Asia than ever before, the impression was of a country overpromising and underdelivering. Washington seemed without a clear strategy for maintaining its influence and countering the rise of China.

The Trump Era: Fundamental Change in Strategy or More of the Same?

Donald Trump ran for office promising to challenge the consensus on US foreign policy, not least in Asia, as part of his "America First" approach. He regularly attacked China on the campaign trail, asserting not only that lopsided bilateral trade practices contributed to a $350 billion trade deficit with China, but also that the decades of opening up American markets to Chinese goods had resulted in the hollowing out of American industries and the loss of millions of jobs. Further, Trump lambasted previous administrations' Korea policy, stating that he would meet with dictator Kim Jong-un and promising that he would prevent North Korea from getting a nuclear weapon that could hit the United States. Overturning decades of practice, Trump explicitly linked security to economic ties with China, arguing that if Beijing did not help solve the North Korean crisis, he would "make trade very difficult."

Surprising many in Washington and Asia, candidate Trump openly questioned the value of the US alliances with Japan and South Korea.